NORTHSTAR COMMERCIAL SOLUTIONS

SG-002 - Sales Discovery & Qualification Guide

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Purpose

Helps sales representatives identify the information required to understand and qualify a customer requirement before making product, solution, commercial, or delivery recommendations. The objective is to find what is known, what materially affects the decision, what is missing, and what should be asked next.

Core Discovery Principle

Good discovery reduces consequential uncertainty. Prioritize questions that can materially change product fit, compatibility, configuration, commercial treatment, deployment feasibility, or customer commitment. Do not ask questions merely because they appear on a generic checklist.

Known, Assumed, and Unknown

Known information is supported by authoritative business data or reliable current requirement context. Assumptions are working assumptions and must not be presented as confirmed truth. Unknowns matter when they can change the recommendation, eligibility, feasibility, or commitment.

Discovery Areas

Depending on the decision: business requirement, capacity and usage, site and utilities, existing equipment, commercial context, and timing/deployment. Only collect fields relevant to the current decision.

Mandatory vs Decision-Supporting Information

Mandatory information is required before a specific claim can be reliably made. Decision-supporting information improves recommendation quality but may allow a limited answer. Missing mandatory evidence limits the affected conclusion.

Ask the Smallest Useful Question

Ask for the smallest amount of information that can materially advance the decision. If the unresolved issue is rear clearance, ask for rear clearance rather than requesting complete site specifications.

Avoid Re-Asking Known Information

Check authoritative internal sources before asking the customer for information already available. Historical internal data should not automatically be treated as current site reality when conditions may have changed.

Customer Statements as Context

Customer or sales statements can establish current requirement context but do not automatically establish unrelated business truth. Preserve consequential unverified statements as context and identify verification needs.

Replacement and Multi-Site Discovery

Do not assume newer equipment is a drop-in replacement or that accessories remain compatible. For multi-site projects, do not automatically apply one site's confirmed conditions to every location.

Capacity and Timing Discovery

Convert vague capacity descriptions into usable operating context when material, without inventing numbers. Distinguish delivery date, installation date, opening date, event date, and go-live date; they are not interchangeable.

Commercial Discovery

Establish customer/account, opportunity, proposed lines, quantities, pre-discount values, product commercial status, current/requested discount, applicable agreement, and sales user/role as needed. Do not infer entitlement from tier, history, or the requested percentage.

Artisan Example

OV-660 is under consideration, but exact site dimensions are missing and applicable rear clearance may depend on production batch. The correct response is to identify available installation clearance and the OV-660 production batch as material unknowns, not to confirm or reject fit prematurely.

Bayfront Example

Urgency does not justify skipping discovery. Separate required production, site space, stock, incoming ETA, site readiness, installation availability, and event deadline. Incoming stock before an event does not prove completed installation before the event.

Discovery Stop Condition

Stop asking when evidence is sufficient for the specific decision. The required depth is claim-dependent.

Clarification and Prioritization

Ask targeted clarification when ambiguity or missing mandatory information could reverse the recommendation, change commercial eligibility, or affect a commitment. Prioritize blockers, decision changers, commitment dependencies, then optimization details.

Qualification Outcome

Identify what is confirmed, what remains unknown, what can be recommended now, what cannot be promised yet, and the smallest useful next action.

Boundaries

This guide cannot invent requirements, treat assumptions as authoritative facts, override technical evidence, establish compatibility or commercial eligibility, authorize discounts, guarantee inventory arrival, confirm installation capacity, override agreements, or resolve authoritative conflicts through sales judgment.

Reasoning Pattern

KNOWN -> DECISION -> REQUIRED EVIDENCE -> GAPS -> NEXT QUESTION. Before asking another question: would the answer materially change what we recommend, approve, or promise?